

# Gen Z Athletic Trends 2025

Annual report on how young consumers buy, judge and talk about athletic apparel and footwear

Cobalt Insight Partners - Consumer Practice

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Fictional data created for the MarketSignal demo.

## 1. Executive summary

Gen Z is the most closely watched consumer cohort in athletic apparel and footwear, and also the least predictable. These shoppers move quickly between channels, form opinions in group chats and creator videos before they ever visit a brand site, and expect sellers to prove their claims rather than simply make them. This first edition of our annual Gen Z Athletic Trends report sets a baseline for four measures that we intend to track every year: the role of social commerce, the size of the opportunity, the weight of sustainability in brand choice, and the breadth of the consideration set that shoppers build before buying.

Four findings stand out in the 2025 data. Social commerce has moved from experiment to a meaningful purchase route for footwear. The cohort is already a large spending pool for athletic apparel. Sustainability claims still shape brand preference for a majority of respondents, though many say they discount claims that are vague. And shoppers consider only a handful of brands before purchase, which means that a brand missing from the early shortlist rarely gets a second chance.

Beyond the headline measures, our open ended questions surfaced a set of frustrations that cut across segments: inconsistent fit and sizing between product lines, uppers and soles that wear out sooner than the price suggests, a strong preference for discovering products through communities rather than advertising, and rising impatience with slow delivery. We treat these as directional themes in this edition and expect to quantify them more precisely as the panel matures.

## 2. Methodology

The 2025 edition draws on an online panel of US consumers aged 16 to 27, fielded over four weeks in June and July 2025. Respondents were recruited through a mix of managed panel partners and opt in communities, screened for at least one purchase of athletic footwear or apparel in the previous twelve months, and weighted to US census margins for age band, gender, region and household income. After quality checks that removed speeders and straight liners, the usable sample was 3,200 respondents.

Purchase channel questions asked about the most recent purchase in each category rather than about general habits, which reduces recall bias but means that results describe purchase occasions and not individual shoppers. Attitude questions used a five point agreement scale; where we report that a share of respondents agree or say something influences them, we are counting the top two boxes. Market sizing combines panel spend data with category revenue reported by public companies and trade sources, and applies a cohort share to the resulting total.

Readers should note two limitations. First, panel members skew slightly toward heavier internet users, which may overstate the prominence of digital channels. Second, the sizing model relies on modeled estimates of how much of each category is bought by consumers in the cohort, and these estimates carry a wider error band than the survey percentages. We have kept the panel design stable and documented every question so that future editions can be compared with this one, and we flag any change in method clearly when it occurs.

The achieved sample was balanced across the three age bands that we use throughout the report, 16 to 18, 19 to 22 and 23 to 27, and included a broad spread of living situations, from students in shared housing to young professionals renting alone. Roughly half of respondents described themselves as playing or training at least three times a week, and the remainder as occasional or lifestyle wearers. We report cuts by these groups only where the differences are large enough to be useful to a reader.

### **3. Social commerce moves into the mainstream**

The clearest structural change in the data is the growth of purchasing inside social platforms. Shoppers describe a loop in which a creator video shows a product on a real body, comments supply sizing advice and reviews, and a shoppable link allows a purchase without leaving the feed. Respondents told us that this sequence feels faster and more trustworthy than a trip to a brand site, even though many still compare prices elsewhere before completing the order.

In 2025, 17% of Gen Z athletic footwear purchases were completed through social commerce platforms. The route is more common for footwear than many retailers assumed, and it is concentrated among younger respondents and among those who report following three or more creators in sport and fitness. Shoppers who bought through social platforms were also more likely to say that they had first noticed the product in a video than in any form of paid search.

For established brands, the implication is not simply to open another storefront. The shoppers we spoke with judge social listings by the quality of the video content, the speed and tone of replies to comments, and the visibility of honest reviews. A weak presence here can damage perception even among shoppers who ultimately buy elsewhere.

Returns and service shape the experience as well. Respondents who bought through social routes were more likely than other shoppers to mention that they had returned an item, usually because of fit, and they expected the return process to be as simple as the purchase. Several told us that a clear returns policy, shown on the listing, was the reason they were willing to buy a brand for the first time.

### **4. Market size**

We size the US Gen Z athletic apparel market at \$41.2 billion for 2025. This figure covers apparel for training, running, studio fitness, team sport and everyday athleisure, and excludes footwear, which we size separately in our footwear annex. The cohort accounts for a share of category spending that is disproportionate to its share of the population, because Gen Z shoppers buy athletic items for both performance and daily wear.

Growth in the cohort is supported by two forces. Younger consumers are still entering the category as they leave school and start work, and existing members are adding categories as their routines broaden from team sport into gym, studio and outdoor activity. Offsetting these are price pressure

and a tendency to trade down to value brands during periods of tight household budgets. Our model assumes that spend per person grows modestly while the number of active buyers grows faster, and we describe the range of outcomes in the appendix tables available to subscribers.

Category mix matters to the sizing. Studio and gym apparel, including leggings, shorts and light layers, accounts for the largest share of cohort spending, followed by everyday tops and hoodies and then team and performance wear. Outerwear is smaller but is growing as respondents extend their wardrobes from training into daily use, and seasonality is more pronounced than for other categories, with a clear peak in autumn.

## **5. Sustainability in brand choice**

62% of Gen Z respondents said sustainability claims influence which athletic brand they choose. The influence is not evenly spread. It is strongest among women, among respondents in the West and Northeast, and among those who describe themselves as regular outdoor participants. It is weakest among shoppers who report that price is their main constraint.

Open responses showed that influence and trust are separate questions. Many shoppers who say sustainability matters also say they struggle to tell whether a claim is real. They ask for simple facts: where the product was made, what share of the material is recycled, and what happens to a worn out pair. Brands that publish those facts in plain language were described as more credible than brands using broad terms such as conscious or planet friendly. We see this as a transparency gap rather than a lack of demand.

We also asked respondents who had bought a product on the strength of a sustainability claim whether they would do so again. Most said yes, but only when the claim had been confirmed by a friend, a review or an independent label. A claim that could not be checked was often seen as a reason to doubt the rest of a brand's messaging, which is why we advise brands to be specific rather than ambitious.

## **6. Brand consideration**

Gen Z shoppers considered an average of 4.1 athletic brands before their most recent purchase. Most of the brands on a typical shortlist are ones the shopper already knew, and entry to the shortlist is driven by social proof, a recommendation from a friend or teammate, and prior ownership. Respondents who bought a brand they had not previously owned were far more likely to say they had seen a peer wearing it.

A narrow shortlist raises the stakes for awareness and for the first impression. Shoppers described eliminating brands quickly on the basis of a sizing complaint, a thin review history or a price that seemed out of line with quality. Value oriented labels were frequently added late in the process, as a check on whether a premium product was worth its price.

## **7. Other trends to watch**

### **7.1 Fit and sizing frustration**

Fit remains the most common complaint in our open ended data. Respondents described wearing different sizes across product categories within one brand, and size charts that failed to match the garments that arrived. Many said they now order two sizes and return one, a habit that is costly for sellers and that respondents regard as a normal cost of shopping online. Brands with a clear exchange promise and consistent grading were praised.

## **7.2 Durability expectations**

Gen Z shoppers pay attention to how products age. Knit uppers and lightweight foams are popular for comfort, yet respondents reported visible wear, fraying and flattening sooner than they expected. Durability complaints appeared most often in reviews of running footwear and were commonly cited when shoppers explained why they would not rebuy a style.

## **7.3 Community discovery**

Run clubs, campus teams, studio classes and group chats act as informal recommendation engines. Shoppers told us that a suggestion from someone they train with carries more weight than any campaign. Brands that sponsor local events, equip instructors, or give community leaders early access to product are building a form of reach that paid media cannot replicate.

## **7.4 Delivery expectations**

Shoppers raised delivery speed unprompted, particularly when buying for an upcoming event, a new season of training or a trip. Free shipping is now taken for granted, and long or uncertain lead times were a common reason for abandoning a basket or choosing another seller. We will add structured questions on delivery windows in future editions so that the pattern can be measured.

# **8. Implications for brands**

- Treat social commerce as a primary route to market with its own creative, service levels and review management, not as an add on to the brand site.
- Build the shortlist early: awareness among younger shoppers is won through peers, community presence and creators, and a narrow consideration set rewards the brands that are already known.
- Publish sustainability facts in plain language, including origin and recycled content, and avoid claims that cannot be evidenced.
- Fix fit consistency and size guidance before investing in new features, since fit problems are the most frequent reason shoppers eliminate a brand.
- Plan product durability and delivery promises with the same care as design, because both shape repeat purchase.

# **9. Outlook**

We expect the cohort to keep gaining weight in athletic spending as more of its members reach full time work, and we expect the channel mix to keep shifting toward social and marketplace routes. We also expect scrutiny of brand claims to rise, as shoppers learn to check them against peer reviews. Our next edition will extend the panel, add a structured delivery module, and report on how

consideration sets evolve. Questions about the data, the questionnaire or the sizing model can be directed to the Consumer Practice team at Cobalt Insight Partners.